

This L.A. enclave needs a defender — now

Westlake’s MacArthur Park is beset by drugs and crime. Someone has to step up and say, ‘Not on my watch.’

STEVE LOPEZ

Early one morning in Westlake, as neighborhood children walked to school, I spotted a woman heading in my direction. She was holding the hand of a little girl who wore a mask, carefully leading her around three people who were sprawled on the pavement.

They were walking on Bonnie Brae Street, a couple blocks east of MacArthur Park, where it’s not uncommon to see people who are either asleep or passed out, with syringes and needles scattered about.

Eduardo Aguirre, the girl’s father, was hustling up behind his family and called my name. I had toured the neighborhood with him one night in September, taking inventory of broken streetlights, a torched playground in the park and countless other problems that have battered Westlake for years. The Aguirres generally don’t let their 6-year-old daughter use the park, even though for them and thousands of other apartment dwellers, it’s the most conveniently located green space.

Aguirre’s wife, Maria, pointed out the wooden planter boxes that had been placed on Bonnie Brae to discourage camping. People squeezed behind them and used the space as a toilet, she said. Aguirre explained that his kindergartner

[See Lopez, A10]



MAX WHITTAKER For The Times

THE SKELETAL remains of three girls — two of them triplets — were found in Eldorado National Forest in 1984.

HE’S STILL ON DEATH ROW. DID LIES PUT HIM THERE?

In 1985, Michael Cox was convicted of killing three girls in the Sierra Nevada. Years later, the two main witnesses recanted.

By Jessica Garrison and Anita Chabria
REPORTING FROM PLACERVILLE, CALIF.

One by one, in the summer of 1984, teenage girls vanished off the streets of this historic town in the foothills of the Sierra Nevada.

Denise Galston disappeared first. She was a skinny 14-year-old with a shy smile and trusting disposition despite a childhood marred by abuse.

Next to go was Lynda Burrill, 18, who had been bullied in high school but was re-inventing herself. She had just moved out of her parents’ wooded home and into a shared house within walking distance to Main Street, which was as much of a party scene as this place had.

The last to vanish was Denise’s sister Debbie (they were two of triplets), who went to a birthday party one night in August and never came home.

Most people figured the girls had run off.

Then their decayed remains began to turn up in the dense national forest that surrounds Placerville, dumped behind rocks or deep in ravines veiled by towering pines.

By the time the third body was discovered that fall, the town was in turmoil. In an era of satanic panic, rumors of a murderous devil-worshipping cult were rampant.

Vengeance and justice have long been intertwined in this Gold Rush outpost, nicknamed Hangtown for its vigilante heritage, and the idea that its daughters were unsafe did not sit well. El Dorado County sheriff’s detectives were under pressure to solve the crimes before more girls went missing. Faced with that urgency, officials took a series of actions that would leave the question of justice elusive for decades to come.

[See Cox, A6]

FDA shaking up its definition of a ‘healthy’ food

Qualifications address sodium, fat and added sugar — good news for avocados, not so much for fruit yogurt.

By Karen Kaplan

In an effort to improve American diets, the U.S. Food and Drug Administration has released a new definition of what it means for a food to qualify as “healthy.”

Products like fruit-flavored yogurt, fortified white bread and sweetened energy bars will no longer be allowed to label themselves as healthy if they exceed certain limits on saturated fat, sodium and added sugars.

At the same time, foods

like salmon, almonds and even water will qualify as healthy for the first time.

The new definition, released Thursday, reflects the advice offered in the Dietary Guidelines for Americans, which are produced by the Department of Agriculture and the Department of Health and Human Services. The hope is that consumers who consider health claims on packaged foods while filling their grocery carts will be steered toward a more nutritious eating pattern, the FDA said.

There’s no question that Americans can use some help with their diets. For example, fewer than half of U.S. adults eat a piece of fruit on any given day, and only 12% consume the recommended 1.5 to 2 cups of fruit per day, according to na-

[See Health, A11]

Bill’s signing averts shutdown of government

Funding is sustained through March 14 and will provide billions in disaster relief and farm aid. **NATION, A4**

Lengthy waits at Loma Linda ER

Patients typically spent roughly seven hours before leaving, a Times analysis found. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Explore eclectic Long Beach

A wealth of neighborhoods delivers diversity, grittiness and fun to both locals and visitors. **WEEKEND, L4**

Weather
Low clouds clearing. L.A. Basin: 66/48. **B8**

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COLUMN ONE

A low-down desert town rallies around the flagpole

Sleepy Calipatria — 184 feet below sea level — takes pride in its 184-foot ‘shining star’ of a staff, which used to be the world’s tallest.

By Hailey Branson-Potts
REPORTING FROM CALIPATRIA, CALIF.

The little desert town of Calipatria, known for its state prison, is a humble place.

It struggles with poverty. It’s in the middle of Imperial County, where the 20% unemployment rate is California’s highest. And some days, its dusty air carries the stench of the polluted Salton Sea eight miles west.

But if you call townsfolk low-down, they won’t take it as an insult.

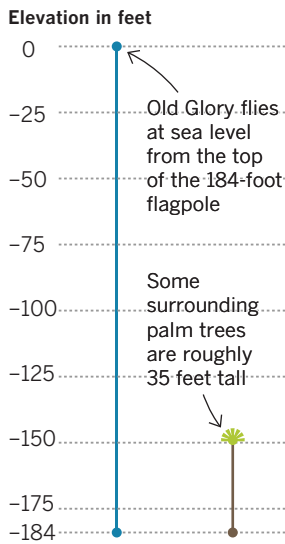
Sitting 184 feet below sea level, Calipatria is the lowest incorporated town in the Western Hemisphere. (Badwater Basin in Death Valley National Park is lower, at 282 feet below, but no one lives there.)

Like many rural towns that don’t have a lot, Calipatria takes pride in what it does have. Its flagpole was once the world’s tallest: a 184-foot staff from which Old Glory flies at sea level.

Edgar Self, the city’s public works director, called it “the shining star” of the

[See Flagpole, A11]

Calipatria’s flagpole



LORENA ELEBEE Los Angeles Times



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